



UNIVERSITY OF GOTHENBURG
DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Course Guide

SK2221, Environmental politics and institutions

Course Administrator:

Wilma Holmestrand (WH) wilma.holmestrand@gu.se

tel. 031-786 69 24

Teachers

Björn Rönnerstrand (BR)	bjorn.ronnerstrand@som.gu.se	tel. 031-786 64 93
Aksel Sundström (AS)	aksel.sundstrom@pol.gu.se	tel. 0762-396118
Niklas Harring (NH)	niklas.harring@pol.gu.se	tel. 031-786 12 23
Markus Johansson (MJ)	markus.johansson@pol.gu.se	tel. 031-786 12 00
Frederik Pfeiffer (PF)	frederik.pfeiffer@gu.se	

1. Introduction

During the course in environmental politics and its institutions, the students will achieve a greater understanding of how societies currently are governing or ought to govern the environment in order to decrease the impact from an array of environmental problems. Examples of such issues the participants will become acquainted with are the challenges found in the marine environment, biodiversity, water and land use, and various airborne environmental problems including climate change. Questions this course will discuss are in what ways actors' environmental behavior is on the one hand explained by factors such as informal institutions, e.g., what values, norms, beliefs and morals the actors are having, and on the other hand formal institutions, e.g., how society is organized, both politically and administratively. This course rests upon a set of theoretical underpinnings, namely, social dilemma theory, institutional theory, theories on opinion and behavior, normative political theory, and game theory.

2. Organization of the Course

The course consists of lectures, seminars, individual tutorials, and written assignments. All seminars are mandatory. The first part of the course is organized in four themes, each of them consisting of lectures, a written assignment, and a seminar.

The course begins with introducing central concepts, environmental issues, and theoretical frameworks, via recorded lecture available on Canvas (Theme 0). Please use the 27th of March to familiarize yourself with this content if you have not previously done so (through SK2223 Environmental Problems within Social Science: From Tragedy of the Commons to Planetary Boundaries, for example).

The course continues with themes on how norms influence environmental behavior (Theme 1) and on the role of institutions in environmental politics (Theme 2). The additional themes starting with a section on environmental politics and international relations (Theme 3), and lastly differences in design of environmental political steering mechanisms (Theme 4).

The remainder of the course is focused on the final course paper and include course paper memo hand-in, tutorials and a final seminar. Each student will compose a course paper in the style of a research plan to be presented at the final seminar.

Canvas

The fastest and most reliable way to find the schedule and to get information about the course is to turn to the course page on Canvas. Course information such as guidelines for assignments, and possible handouts are available on the course page. All assignments should also be handed in via Canvas (besides Memo 2 and Memo 3, who are e-mailed to respective teachers). You will be informed of any changes, additions, etc. on the course page, as well as by email to the participants' listed e-mail addresses on Canvas.

Please avoid using messaging through Canvas, you will get a response much faster when using e-mail.

Literature

There are a course book (below), and additional articles and book chapters listed for the respective themes.

Ostrom, Elinor. E., Dietz, Thomas. E., Dolšák, Nives . E., Stern, Paul. C., Stonich, Susan. E., & Weber, Elke. U. (2002). *The drama of the commons*. National Academy Press. 534 pages.

The chapters from this book are available in full-text for free through the university library. See https://gu-se-primo.hosted.exlibrisgroup.com/primo-explore/search?query=any,contains,The%20drama%20of%20the%20commons&vid=46GUB_VU1&search_scope=default_scope&sortby=rank&lang=sv_SE

In some themes, there will also be optional reading, for those interested.

Written assignments

Assignment instructions for seminars one through four

Write a paper (2000 words) where you answer the question(s) assigned to each theme (Theme 1-4). The weekly papers are an overview of the readings which means that all papers should be included. No bullet points, text justified to the margins and APA referencing style. At the seminar, you should be prepared to discuss the questions for the assignment, as well as the assigned course literature for that theme. Hand in via Canvas before the seminar, no later than 09.00 AM the same day as the seminar.

Important: the assignment requires specific references to page numbers in respective texts.

For the seminars, students will be divided into two groups

Instructions for course paper memo

There are three memos in total.

Write a short memo (500-750 words) introducing a proposal for the course paper. Hand in via Canvas before 16.00, 29/4.

Memo 2 is a more developed version, word length dependent on your own progress at this point. Hand in by e-mailing the teacher assigned as supervising you before 16.00, 08/5.

Memo 3 is a more developed version, word length dependent on your own progress at this point. Hand in by e-mailing the teacher assigned as supervising you before 16.00, 19/5.

Instructions for course paper

The purpose of the course paper is to independently produce a research plan suitable for a master's thesis, including the components listed below. The course paper doesn't involve actually conducting any empirical investigation. Instead, it gives you the possibility to focus your discussion on theory and methods.

We anticipate that the course paper should propose a study that is relevant to the field of collective action research/ and or environmental politics and institutions. Under each of the four components, a number of specific elements are listed that you should consider while writing your course paper (but you do not need to follow them slavishly).

1. An introduction with a clearly motivated research problem and aim. In this section, consider the following elements:
 - a. Motivate the relevance of the study by, for instance highlighting knowledge gaps in science or policy discussions.
 - b. The aim should be sufficiently specific for a study of the scope of a master's thesis.
 - c. The aim should be presented in the light of existing research such that the contribution made to academic discussions is made clear.
2. An overview of a theoretical framework/previous research. In this section, consider the following elements:
 - a. Define relevant concepts and the delimitation of your proposed study.
 - b. Review the research field relevant for motivating your question(s).
 - c. Specify the theoretical point of departure and ensure that it lays the foundation of the thesis' investigation.

3. Research question(s). In this section, consider the following element:
 - a. The research aim(s) and questions should interrelate to one another such that answers to the individual research questions will result in fulfilling the aim of the study.
4. Methodological reflections, including design and data. In this section, consider the following elements:
 - a. If operationalizations and measurements are discussed, ensure that they are clearly connected to theory and prior research.
 - b. Discuss validity and reliability of your study.
 - c. Scope: This section on methodological reflections should be rather short, preferably around one page (deviations are accepted but this should not be the larger section in the course paper).

The course paper should be around 6000 words ($\pm 10\%$), excluding references. After submitting your course paper memo, you will be assigned a supervisor who will guide you through the process.

Compensations for seminar non-attendance post-deadline submissions

All seminars are mandatory. If you do not attend a theme seminar you need to compensate by handing in an extra assignment (in addition to the seminar assignment). This should be an essay consisting of about 1500 words, focused on reviewing and critically discuss the strengths and weaknesses of two articles assigned to the theme you didn't attend. If you miss the final seminar, you compensate this by an essay consisting of about 2000 words, focused on reviewing and critically discuss the strengths and weaknesses of two other students' final essays. These supplementary assignments should be handed in via Canvas.

If you do not submit seminar assignments or the course paper on time there will be an additional opportunity to submit in August.

The Department of Political Science uses the Ouriginal plagiarism control system. We are obliged to report suspicion of cheating to the Disciplinary Board at GU. The use of AI services (like ChatGPT and Grammarly) is not permitted in any of the written assignments.

Theme 0

NOTE: If you have taken the course "SK2223 Environmental Problems within Social Science: From Tragedy of the Commons to Planetary Boundaries" this theme will be very familiar.

Recorded lectures available at Canvas

Intro lecture 1

This introductory lecture primarily serves as an update for those who have not studied environmental issues before. Thus, we start by elaborating on what the word "environment" actually refers to. We then discuss the geneses of environmental problems, i.e., why do they arise

despite the fact that we know rather well what the consequences will be. This brings us into collective action theory, followed by a short discussion about various responses to environmental problems.

Intro lecture 2

We start by briefly account for the history of environmental politics – when did it all start, how has it developed over time? Based on what has been said about collective action (theory) in the previous lecture, we thereafter start digging into the broad field of environmental politics, starting with what political system is best suited to cope with environmental challenges, followed by how environmental politics can be organized and natural resources be managed in an effective way. The lecture ends with a brief discussion about more specific policies and policy instruments (something which will be further elaborated in the lecture during Theme 4).

There is no paper or seminar on this theme.

Literature

Baumgärtner, Stefan, Becker, Christian, Faber, Malte, & Manstetten, Reiner. (2006). Relative and absolute scarcity of nature. Assessing the roles of economics and ecology for biodiversity conservation. *Ecological Economics*, 59:4, 11 pages.

Duus-Otterström, Göran & Jagers, Sverker C. (2012). Identifying burdens of coping with climate change: A typology of the duties of climate justice. *Global Environmental Change* 22:3, 6 pages.

Jagers, Sverker C., Harring, Niklas, Löfgren, Åsa, Sjöstedt, Martin, mfl. (2019) On the preconditions for large-scale collective action. (2019) On the preconditions for large-scale collective action. *Ambio*, 15 pages.

Mansbridge, Jane. (2014) The role of the state in governing the commons. *Environmental Science & Policy* 36, 3 pages.

Ungaro, Daniele. (2005) Ecological Democracy. *International Review of Sociology*, 15:2, 10 pages.

Theme 1

Lecture: Environmental politics and international relations: prospects and challenges (MJ)

The lecture will discuss how the international and European environments are governed by different international organizations, including the European Union. Focus will be on the states as the central actors in the international system. It will discuss how the environment is regulated outside the nation state, and the how compliance by the signatory states is secured (or not). In doing so, it will focus in particular on the concepts of soft and hard international law, how they differ and what different types of regulation means for the effectiveness of international law-making.

Seminar Assignment

For this weeks' hand-in, please respond to the questions below.

1. Discuss the benefits and drawbacks of soft and hard law (legalization) in governing the environment on the international level. Make an assessment of whether you believe that the current international climate regime is in need of more hard law (or less), and if so in what respect.
2. Discuss the prospects and obstacles for how that can be achieved. In addition to reviewing the literature, you might also be helped in your discussion by looking at the actual Paris agreement and supporting information on the UNFCCC webpages:

https://unfccc.int/sites/default/files/english_paris_agreement.pdf

<https://unfccc.int/process-and-meetings/the-paris-agreement/the-paris-agreement>

Literature

Required:

Abbott, Kenneth W., Keohane, Robert O., Moravcsik, Andrew, Slaughter, Anne-Marie and Snidal, Duncan (2000) "The Concept of Legalization", *International Organization*, 54(3): 401-419.

Bodansky, Daniel (2016) "The Paris Climate Change Agreement: A New Hope?", *American Journal of International Law*, 110(2): 288-319.

Dimitrov, Radoslav, Hovi, Jon, Sprinz, Detlef F., Saelen, Håkon and Underdal, Arild (2019) "Institutional and environmental effectiveness: Will the Paris Agreement work?" *Wiley Interdisciplinary Reviews: Climate Change*, 10(4), e583.

Keohane, Robert O. and Victor, David G. (2016) "Cooperation and discord in global climate policy", *Nature Climate Change*, 6: 570-575

Optional:

Abbott, Kenneth W. and Snidal, Duncan (2000) "Hard and Soft Law in International Governance", *International Organization*, 54(3):421-456.

Keohane, Robert O. and Oppenheimer, Michael (2016) "Paris: Beyond the Climate Dead End through Pledge and Review?", *Politics and Governance*, 4(3): 142-151.

Tingley, Dustin and Tomz, Michael (2022) "The Effects of Naming and Shaming on Public Support for Compliance with International Agreements: An Experimental Analysis of the Paris Agreement", *International Organization*, 76(2): 445–68.

Tørstad, Vegard, Saelen, Håkon and Standal Bøyum, Live (2020) "The domestic politics of international climate commitments: which factors explain cross-country variation in NDC ambition?", *Environmental Research Letters*, 15.

Theme 2

Lecture: Institutional theory, state-society relations, and environmental politics (AS)

This lecture focuses on institutions and natural resource management as well as the role of the state in fostering compliance and sustainable use of natural resources. It builds closely on the introductory lectures but aims to focus more closely on central concepts and institutional theory. It also emphasizes the important role of the state and gives empirical examples on how country characteristics and regime types tend to affect natural resource exploitation. The empirical examples come primarily from wildlife, fisheries and water management.

Seminar (FP)

For this week's hand-in, please respond to the questions below.

1. Define and describe a *common pool resource*. Discuss why such resources run the risk of overexploitation and how various institutional solutions potentially can solve the problems associated with these kinds of resources.
2. In addition, **choose one of the two themes** to discuss:
 1. Consider the case of migratory wildlife in African Peace Parks: What kind of institutions potentially govern those resources? Are the institutions formal or informal? How are the institutionalized rules enforced? Is it likely that resource users will comply? Why? Why not?
 2. Consider the case of the five Turkish fisheries described by Berkes: What kind of institutions govern those resources? Are the institutions formal or informal? What is the property regime in the different fisheries and how could this affect collective action? Is the institutional arrangement successful in sustainably managing the resource? Why? Why not?

At the seminar, we will discuss these questions together. You will also be expected to engage in group work to apply the lessons learned from this theme to a CPR of your choosing, discussing the main challenges and institutional solutions.

Literature

Required:

Arias, Adrian. 2015. Understanding and managing compliance in the nature conservation context. *Journal of Environmental Management*, 153, 134-143.

Duffy, Rosaleen, Francis Massé, Emile Smidt, Esther Marijnen, Bram Büscher, Judith Verweijen, Maano Ramutsindela, Trishant Simlai, Laure Joanny, and Elizabeth Lunstrum. (2019). Why We Must Question the Militarisation of Conservation. *Biological Conservation* 232: 66–73.

Berkes, Fikret. 1986. Local-level management and the commons problem: A comparative study of Turkish coastal fisheries. *Marine Policy* 10 (3): 215-229.

Linell, A., Sjöstedt, M. & Sundström, A. (2019) Governing transboundary commons in Africa: the emergence and challenges of the Kavango–Zambezi Treaty. *International Environmental Agreements* 19, 53–68.

Sundström, A. (2015) Covenants with broken swords: Corruption and law enforcement in governance of the commons. *Global Environmental Change*, 31: 253-262.

Ostrom, Elinor. E., Dietz, Thomas. m.fl. 2002. The drama of the commons: National Academy Press. Chapter 1-2.

Chapter 1 - Dietz, Dolsak, Ostrom, Stern - "The Drama of the Commons"
Chapter 2 - Agrawal - "Common Resources and Institutional Sustainability"

Optional:

Becker, Dustin, and Ostrom, Elinor 1995. Human Ecology and Resource Sustainability: The Importance of Institutional Diversity. *Annual Review of Ecology and Systematics* 26: 113-133.

Mansbridge, Jane. 2014. What is Political Science for?. *Perspectives on Politics*, 12(1), 8-17.

Sjöstedt, Martin. 2013. Horizontal and vertical resource dilemmas in natural resource management: the case of African fisheries. *Fish & Fisheries* 14(4): 616-624.

Theme 3

Lecture: Can trust, reciprocity, reputation and social norms explain voluntary (environmental) collective action (BR)

The standard rational choice theory of collective action theory predict that people will not cooperate when group benefits and individual benefits collide. While conflicting individual group-level and individual benefits make cooperation difficult, we still observe ample evidence that people sidestep their individual benefits for the sake of the collective. People vote, demonstrate, donate, pay taxes and recycle, contrary to the classical predictions. A behavioral approach to collective action describes cooperation to be a product of for example trust, reciprocity, reputation and social norms. We will discuss whether trust, reciprocity, reputation and norms matter for cooperation using evidence from laboratory public good experiments, cross-national surveys and natural experiments. Many of the previous studies have found evidence of such relationships on a small scale. Is trust reciprocity, reputation and social norms as important for cooperation in large-scale collective action?

Seminar Assignment

For this weeks' hand-in, discuss potential avenues for future research on the role of trust, reciprocity and reputation in large-scale collective action, particularly focusing the transferability of findings from small-scale to large-scale collective action problems.

Literature

Required:

Cook, Karen S. & State, Bogdan. (2017). Trust and Social Dilemmas. In Trust in Social Dilemmas (Series in human cooperation). Lange, P., Rockenbach, B., & Yamagishi, T (eds.). Oxford Scholarship Online [E-book].

Gächter, Simon and Benedikt Herrmann (2009). "Reciprocity, culture and human cooperation: previous insights and a new cross-cultural experiment." *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society B: Biological Sciences* 364(1518): 791-806.

Ostrom, Elinor. (1998). "A Behavioral Approach to the Rational Choice Theory of Collective Action: Presidential Address, American Political Science Association, 1997." *The American Political Science Review* 92(1): 1-22.

Ostrom, Elinor. E., Dietz, Thomas. E., Dolšák, Nives . E., Stern, Paul. C., Stonich, Susan. E., & Weber, Elke. U. (2002). The drama of the commons. National Academy Press. Chapter 4

Rönnerstrand, B., Carelli, D., Pierre, J., & Lampi, E. (2022). Leviathan versus the super bugs: free riding drives support for EU power over antimicrobial resistance. *Journal of European Integration*, 44(8), 1041-1057.

Optional:

Bowles, Samuel, and Herbert Gintis. 1998. "The Moral Economy of Communities: Structured Populations and the Evolution of Pro-Social Norms." *Evolution and Human Behavior* 19 (1): 3-25.

Frey, Bruno S., & Meier, Stephen. (2004). Social comparisons and pro-social behavior: Testing" conditional cooperation" in a field experiment. *American Economic Review*, 94(5), 1717-1722.

Milinski, Manfred, et al. (2002). "Reputation helps solve the 'tragedy of the commons'." *Nature* 415(6870): 424-426.

Theme 4

Lecture: Environmental policy instruments (NH)

The lecture will address the critical role of public support in ensuring the effectiveness of climate and environmental policy instruments and discuss the several factors and motivators influencing

policy support, with a particular emphasis on the role of individuals' perceptions of fairness in determining their support or rejection of climate and environmental policy instruments.

Seminar Assignment

For this weeks' hand-in, please respond to the questions below.

1. Discuss the significance of fairness perceptions in shaping individuals' support and acceptance of climate policy measures (in particular carbon pricing), and elaborate on how various fairness concepts and principles influence public acceptance and support.
2. Discuss how different societal groups may vary in their perceptions about fairness and climate policy measures.

Literature

Required:

Coleman, E. A., Harring, N., & Jagers, S. C. (2023). Policy attributes shape climate policy support. *Policy Studies Journal*, 1–19.

Drews, Stefan & van den Bergh, Jeroen C.J.M. (2016). What explains public support for climate policies? A review of empirical and experimental studies. *Climate Policy* 16(7): 855-876.

Maestre-Andrés, Sara, Drews, Stefan & van den Bergh, Jeroen. (2019). Perceived fairness and public acceptability of carbon pricing: a review of the literature. *Climate Policy* 19(9): 1186-1204.

Povitkina, M., Jagers, S. C., Matti, S., & Martinsson, J. (2021). Why are carbon taxes unfair? Disentangling public perceptions of fairness. *Global Environmental Change*, 70, 102356.

Optional:

Andre, P., Boneva, T., Chopra, F., & Falk, A. (2024). Globally representative evidence on the actual and perceived support for climate action. *Nature Climate Change*

Bergquist, M., Nilsson, A., Harring, N. & Jagers, S.C (2022). Meta-analyses of fifteen determinants of public opinion about climate change taxes and laws. *Nature Climate Change* 12, 235–240

Davidovic, Dragana, Harring, Niklas & Jagers, Sverker C. (2019). The contingent effects of environmental concern and ideology: institutional context and people's willingness to pay environmental taxes. *Environmental Politics* 29(4): 674-696.

Harring, Niklas, Jagers, Sverker C. & Matti, Simon. (2018). The significance of political culture, economic context and instrument type for climate policy support: a cross-national study. *Climate Policy* 19(5): 636-650.

Harring, Niklas. (2016). Reward or Punish? Understanding preferences toward economic or regulatory instruments in a cross-national perspective. *Political Studies* 64(3): 573-592.

Kyselá, Eva, Scasný, Milan & Zverinová, Iva. (2019). Attitudes toward climate change mitigation policies: a review of measures and a construct of policy attitudes. *Climate Policy* 19(7): 878-892.

3. Schedule

See Canvas.

4. Assessment

Student performance is assessed through five written assignments: four individually written seminar paper where various aspects of environmental politics and collective action theory are to be discussed (4 hec) and an individual final course paper (11 hec).

5. Grades

The grading scale comprises: Pass with Distinction (VG), Pass (G) and Fail (U). To obtain the Pass grade, the student must receive a Pass on all forms of assessment. The seminar assignments are awarded either Pass (G) or Fail (U). The course paper is awarded Pass with Distinction (VG), Pass (G) and Fail (U). To obtain Pass with Distinction for the entire course, a student must receive a Pass with Distinction (VG) on the final essay, as well as Pass on all seminar assignments.

6. Learning Outcomes

A student who has passed the course will be able to

Knowledge and understanding:

- Show in-depth knowledge about different conceptualizations of environmental problems, and environmental politics in a comparative perspective.
- Show in-depth knowledge about collective action and social dilemma theory, including factors generating collective action such as values, attitudes, norms, beliefs, uncertainty, trust, media and various policy instruments available to create collective action as well as the challenges associated with the implementation of these policy instruments.

Skills and abilities

- Compare and critically assess advanced institutional theories and frameworks.
- Use institutional theory to explain the genesis of environmental problems and lack of collective action, as well as how institutions simultaneously can promote environmental collective action.
- Through independent work, plan and conduct a minor research project addressing

central aspects of environmental collective action and effectively communicate this plan.

- Independently produce text in accordance with good academic practice, including proper citation technique, use of references, and within the given time frame.

Judgement and approach

- Systematize and integrate different theories about formal and informal institutions' impact on collective action and environmental behavior.

7. About equal treatment

The University of Gothenburg aims to promote equal rights and opportunities for students and employees and to combat discrimination related to gender, gender identity or gender expressions, ethnicity, religion or other beliefs, sexual orientation, disability, or age. If, however, you as a student at the Department of Political Science become subject to such acts and actions, we encourage you to contact us to enable the opportunity for appropriate action. You can contact: the course coordinator, director of studies Agnes Cornell, or student counselor Eva Nilsson. Student counselors have confidentiality. You can also turn to these persons if you experience problems or discomfort in the study environment, even if not targeted at you. All contact information is available on our website.

8. Academic Writing

The three hallmarks of good academic writing are clarity, precision, and intellectual honesty. Unlike some other forms of writing, academic texts should be free from ambiguity, and they should offer the reader plainly stated arguments, not rhetorical tricks. This does not mean that they have to be boring, of course, but it does mean that, whenever there is a conflict between being linguistically elegant and clear, the latter should take precedence. For example, in academic writing, it might be preferable to consistently use the same terms for the same concepts instead of using synonyms, even though this would be dull in other types of writing (such as fiction). To organize the text, a good rule of thumb is to make one point per paragraph.

Good academic writing is cumulative; it proceeds from, communicates with, and seeks to contribute to previous work on the topic of choice. It is essential that the author (or authors) gives due credit to previous work. There should never be any doubt as to whether segments of text, ideas, claims or results are the author's own or drawn from other sources. To ensure this, academic writing requires a transparent system of citation. Never 'copy and paste' text from other sources without citing those sources and enclosing direct quotes in quotation marks. Copying text without indicating it is a quotation constitutes plagiarism. Use references consistently and accurately. These requirements hold for all academic texts, from short student assignments and course papers to master theses and academic books and journal articles.

Please see our note above on the use of AI services, which are generally not permitted in written assignments.

Further information and relevant links are found on the course *Canvas page*.